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Despicable digital banter: Racist black and brown politicians in the U.K.

by Craig Ryder

Abstract

The aim of this paper is to introduce the phrase ‘digital banter’ to describe a highly localised typology of English-language speech that acts to veil xenophobia, misogyny, and other forms of extremism. Via an analysis of various videos on the sacking of British Foreign Secretary Suella Braverman, uploaded to the fringe social media platform Bitchute, this paper reveals certain aspects of the state of British politics and culture *vis-à-vis* platform norms and sociotechnical Internet subcultures. First, digital banter is a mode of anti-fandom that relies on a vocal dislike for non-white and non-male, seeking to dehumanise and delegitimise the identities and experiences of black and brown female politicians. While the principal point of attention for fan/anti-fan communities has historically been celebrities, politicians are increasingly becoming the focus of digital banter in Internet subcultures. Second, those profiting from political anti-fandom are called “banter merchants”, pointing towards mercantile imperatives that motivate social media creators to accrue influence through political anti-fandom. On Bitchute, serious political discussion is reduced to memetic ecologies of viral trends, rage, and shitposting, whilst signposting users toward a cascade of other platforms, paid subscriptions, and merchandise purchases. This research makes the case, however, that the extreme attitudes and behaviours witnessed on Bitchute are endlessly reproduced and reflected — albeit perhaps more softly and, therefore, more insidiously — throughout the British media ecosystem.

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Introduction

A Scottish man sporting a snapback cap, hoodie, and a long ginger beard smiles into the camera as he begins his videoblog on the fringe U.K.-based social media platform Bitchute.

"Big Mama Braverman has got the *yeat*", he announces, deploying Scottish slang for "*sack*".

"And I liked Braverman. I *liked* her, I mean, I *liked* her *opinions*", he says, before bursting into laughter, adding with a wink, "if you know what I mean?"

Once he regains his composure, he continues. "She has got the *yeat* [sack] because she has a very hardline stance on immigration, which, you know, scored her a lot of points with me."

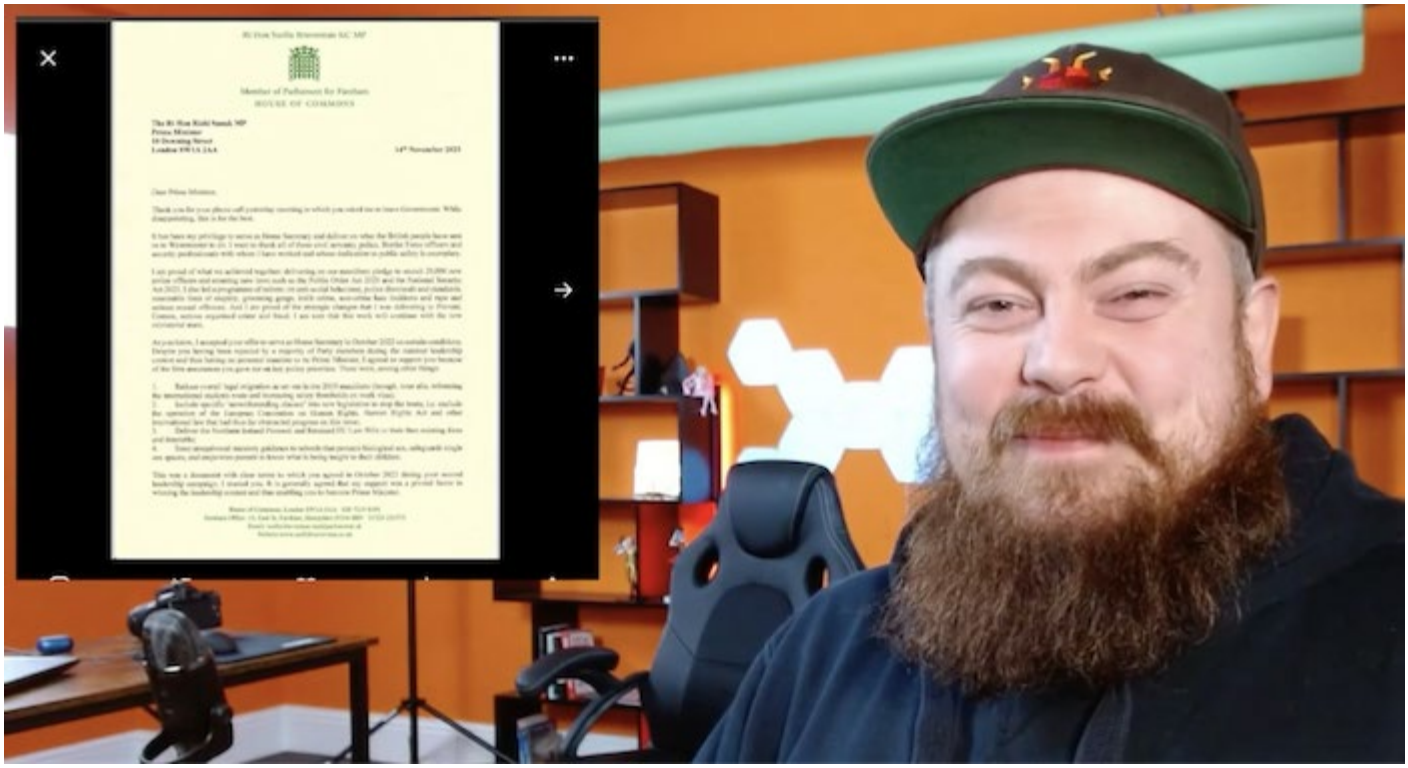


Figure 1: Count Dankula in his familiar gab of cap, hoodie, and long beard. His bursting smirk is demonstrative of the playful banter embedded in his political commentary.

The video was posted on 15 November 2023 on Bitchute, two days after the U.K. Home Secretary, Suella Braverman, was sacked from her position in the ruling Conservative government. The talking head in the video is "Count Dankula", a popular Bitchute political influencer who, over the past seven years, has posted more than 1,600 videos to the alternative video-sharing platform. Discussing current affairs with a heavy dose of humour mixed with right-wing rhetoric, Count Dankula has amassed an impressive 21,000 subscribers.

The opening 20 seconds of the 12-minute video vividly encapsulates the contemporary political environment in the U.K. in all its toxic irony and complexity. Let me try and summarise it in three sentences. A woman of colour, Suella Braverman, has risen to the upper echelons of power in the U.K. based on her hardline ethnopolitics and anti-immigration rhetoric and policies. She was sacked by the Prime Minister, Rishi Sunak, also a person of colour, because of Braverman's public accusation that the London Metropolitan Police demonstrated bias against far-right protestors over pro-Palestine supporters, thereby undermining the authority of the state apparatus in the U.K. The white Scotsman hosting the video laughs at Braverman's sacking because while "he liked her opinions", he did not, and could not, actually like her

because of the colour of her skin. This triple layer of racism is thinly veiled by the humorous tone of the video. While the sniggering, slang, and in-jokes do not detract too much from the underlying message of racism, they appear to make it less despicable.

Bitchute belongs to the burgeoning “alt-tech” platform ecosystem (Rogers, 2020) that has emerged to offer content creators and consumers alternative digital spaces that afford laxer content moderation practices, and therefore harbour more extreme content compared to the major social media platforms. Bitchute is different to the majority of so-called alt-tech platforms because it was founded in the U.K., not the U.S., where alt-tech platforms — such as Gab, Odysee, Rumble, and Truth Social — are financed by notorious right-wing politicians and investors. Differently, Bitchute relies solely on subscriptions, donations, and advertisers for income. With no financial investors to appease, Bitchute, does not have an editorial line to follow and can truly live up to its libertarian philosophy and promise of freedom of speech. Count Dankula is one of many ideological entrepreneurs (Finlayson, 2023) who produce content on alternative platforms that actively cultivate hate and extreme politics, whilst benefiting from the attention economy that platform logics foster. By remixing current affairs topics into presenter-style videos that resemble legacy media news segments, but underwritten by personal opinion and laced with outlandish humour, Count Dankula leads and emulates a common trope and pattern of behaviours. Content creators are empowered to adopt local vernacular, coded linguistic practices, and elaborate body politics to re-report the news to be palatable to highly localised fanbases. Often, they speak purposefully at the camera, or host 1-2-1 interviews with “experts”, or four-person panels imitating professional TV talk shows. Some superimpose news studios into their backgrounds, some cut-and-paste library images from the professional news into their videos, whilst others take to the streets in classic news reporter fashion. A recurring theme amongst these creators is how jokes and laughter seem to overlay outward expressions of hate and outrage.

The purpose of this paper is not to explain the intricacies of jokes deployed by political influencers such as Count Dankula. Rather, we introduce and explain the phrase ‘digital banter’ to describe a highly localised typology of speech that acts to veil xenophobia, misogyny, and other forms of extremism. Banter is considered to be a quintessential element of English discursivity. Jobert and Sorlin (2018) noted that the word banter “does not really translate [into other languages], suggesting therefore that banter may well be a cultural trait” [1]. Historians trace the word banter back to seventeenth-century theatre, where it originated as a mode of causing offence. Throughout the twentieth century, banter has proliferated into contemporary mainstream U.K. culture, including the TV game show *Pointless* (Pillière, 2018) and the celebrated works of comedy troupe Monty Python (Sorlin, 2018). Since *The Office*, where loser regional manager, David Brent, relied on excruciating identity politics to elevate his own self-esteem, banter has become more broadly understood as a way to veil or excuse everyday expressions of racism, sexual harassment, and other forms of bullying behind a facade of humour (Jobert and Sorlin, 2018). Digital banter is therefore not a new form of verbal abuse, rather it is a digitalisation of a very British style of interaction and interrogation. I understand digital banter as a cultural repertoire of extreme speech to help “contextualize online debate with attention to user practices and particular histories of speech cultures” [2]. What was once a source of pride among the British — good humour and spirited verbal jousting — has been recast as a political vehicle to disguise (and normalise) racism and sexism. Indeed, it may well remain a source of pride among some Brits.

The extreme speech theoretical framework put forward by Pohjonen and Sahana (2017) shifted analysis away from the faux binary between hate speech and an acceptable other, to a spectrum of extremism that recognises context and culturally coded circumstances. This intervention serves not only to understand the accusation of ‘hate speech’ as a normative descriptor, at times weaponized by the powerful to muzzle opposition and nullify dissent, but also serves to construct highly localised repertoires of extreme speech that foster community and oil the mechanisms for inclusion and exclusion. By adopting an anthropological approach to online speech that is sensitive to socio-cultural settings, including linguistic history, platform norms, and sociotechnical Internet subcultures, I understand digital banter within the British platform ecosystem as closer to a form of anti-fandom based on the cultural experience of dislike (Gray, 2021, 2019, 2003) rather than the psychological conceit of hate. As a repertoire of British extreme speech, digital banter may well have internationally comparable analogues. Donald Trump’s “locker-room chat” — his

despicable “grab them by the pussy” rhetoric — may be an American “jock” equivalent because it also normalises misogyny and racism in the political sphere, yet it is less banter-like because it lacks the wit of the British.

Whilst wanting to qualify digital banter as a cultural phenomenon that warrants our attention, this work grapples with a serious double-tension that it aims to handle critically, but with care. The context of Count Dankula’s despicable digital banter is the rise and fall of Suella Braverman, a British female politician of mixed Indian and East African heritage. While the mediation of female politicians has been extensively studied, with research examining their representation in mainstream media (Adcock, 2010; Garcia-Blanco and Wahl-Jorgensen, 2012) and social media (*e.g.*, Southern and Harmer, 2021), what these studies lack is an analysis of the ethnic intersectionality of female leaders. The rise of female ethnically-minority leaders has captivated British politics in recent years, as also exemplified by Braverman’s colleague, Priti Patel, and the subsequent emergence of Kemi Badenoch — new leader of the Conservative party and the first female ethnic minority leader of a mainstream political party in Europe. But while Braverman, Patel, and Badenoch are all victims of conspicuous racism and misogyny by content creators such as a Count Dankula on social media, these extraordinarily influential politicians also explicitly express xenophobic and dangerous rhetoric towards migrants and people of colour, intensifying and complicating hostility by extreme far-right actors. That is why Count Dankula says he *likes* Braverman — *well, he likes her policies anyway*. This sets me up with a difficult tension to grapple with. As an empathic scholar, I want to express solidarity and progressive values towards the rise of female ethnically minority leaders because I believe it is critical we condemn racists and despicable narratives against women and all people of colour. I also want to condemn the despicable narratives that these three leaders have espoused in recent years, whilst not suggesting that their toxic rhetoric gives reason or warrants toxic abuse, whether digital banter or otherwise.

Outline

I begin by establishing digital banter as a typically British form of speech that uses humour for political affect. By considering digital banter a digitalised repertoire of an existing British linguistic formation, I simultaneously connect digital banter to what has gone before *and* question what is new about it in an era of politically charged discourse via social media platforms. One of my objectives in locating these speech strategies within the anthropological approach to extreme speech is to demonstrate how the English vernacular typology of digital banter, whilst singularly British, relies on techniques and speech acts familiar in cross-cultural settings. Before a brief note on methodology, I then move on to argue that the conceptualisation of digital banter reveals several aspects of the state of British politics and culture *vis-à-vis* platform norms and sociotechnical Internet subcultures. In the first section, I situate digital banter as a mode of anti-fandom that relies on a vocal dislike for the non-white and non-male that seeks to dehumanise and delegitimise the identities and experiences of black and brown female politicians. While the principal point of attention for fan/anti-fan communities has historically been celebrities, politicians, who also crave visibility and engagement, are increasingly becoming the topic of digital banter among Internet subcultures. By considering Suella Braverman as an emerging type of celebrity-politician that invites *bad object anti-fandom* characterised by more than “a general popular dislike” [3], grounded in implicit modes of racism and misogyny, I consider the generous reception received on social media to humour, aesthetics, and shock over the more pragmatic goals of presenting reliable information that favours solemn integrity and earnestness. In the second section, I call content creators such as Count Dankula banter merchants to point towards the mercantile imperatives that motivates social media creators to accrue political influence through comedic anti-fandom. While content creators of these kinds are traditionally called influencers, I argue that a new typology of banter merchants better describes the prioritisation of entertainment and monetisation over serious political discussion. On Bitchute, serious political discussion is reduced to memetic ecologies of viral trends, rage and shitposting, whilst signposting users toward a cascade of other platforms, paid subscriptions, and merchandise purchases. Finally, I move on to conclude how banter merchants generate *networked parasocial relationships* — between themselves and their fans, but also

between the object of their anti-fandom, Suella Braverman, and their fans. The comments and attitudes that fans then share below the line on social media solidify racist and misogynist narratives by reproducing the playful tone. These strategies create an anti-fan community in and of itself, informed by digital banter as a political act, that works to establish norms and codes of conduct whilst conversing in the alternative small platform ecosystem (and potentially beyond).

Digital banter: A British linguistic formulation

If as Jobert and Sorlin [4] stated that British people use "banter as a universal excuse to legitimise sexism, racism, bullying and verbal offence at large", it merits serious consideration as to what this political act accomplishes and how it contributes to broader societal norms when digitalised. The use of misogyny, nationalism, and other exclusionary tropes is notable across the wider British media ecology. Long held for its world leading British Broadcasting Corporation (BBC), measured media regulations and commitment to freedom of speech, the U.K. media sphere is littered with scandals and accusations of indecency, some more resolved than others. Several of the most recognisable comedic performers in British cultural life, including Jimmy Savile, Russell Brand, Greg Wallace (the list is very long), are under investigation for serious and egregious harms against women. These men, who have predominately risen to fame through mainstream TV, are renowned for their comic personas and colourful wordplay. Not only does this imply that banter normalises misogyny, but it actively mobilises it, and in plain sight.

While banter prevails, the British media sphere is undergoing rapid and significant change. Like elsewhere, in the face of rapid platformisation of media and culture, traditional newsrooms are shrinking (Ponsford, 2024), revenues are plummeting (Lu, 2024), and audiences are disengaging (Newman, *et al.*, 2024). In the digital ecosystem, the U.K.'s new Online Safety Act (2023) [5] has been primarily installed to protect users from being exposed to adult or inappropriate content. However, the new policy, which demands age verification for various everyday online activities, including social media, has been broadly criticised as draconian. Critically, in response to the Online Safety Act, in May 2025 Bitchute discontinued its services in the U.K., citing the stringent regulatory environment as untenable. While Bitchute remains operational in other countries, thousands of U.K. creators and users, including myself whilst conducting this research, continue to access the platform only via a VPN. It is beyond the scope of this paper to investigate whether Bitchute's decision to discontinue services in the U.K. was due to policy that demands platforms invest significantly in AI systems for age verification via facial recognition, and to monitor and remove content. However, I want to question the wisdom of policies that target so-called problematic platforms such as Bitchute, rendering them either obsolete or pushing them further underground, when the extreme attitudes and behaviours witnessed on Bitchute in the form of digital banter are not unique to the alt-tech platform, but endlessly reproduced and reflected — albeit perhaps more softly, and, therefore, more insidiously — throughout the British digital media ecosystem.

For example, when I type into YouTube 'what is banter?' the first video presented is a 30-second clip of two white men in the front of a van. In Britain, the "man in a van" image instantly evokes the epitome of working-class masculinity, notorious for misogynistic catcalls and wolf whistles, aimed at women on the street. In the short video clip, a mobile phone rings and the man in the driving seat answers it. Repeatedly, he says to the caller in thick Cockney timbre, "you'll *DOO what*", as the other man looks on from the passenger seat. "You're gonna to *DOOO what* to me?" the main man shrieks, getting his friend's excited attention as it starts to become clear that the call is of explicitly sexual nature. "Oh, you saucy cow!" he exclaims, before passing the phone to his friend, saying "'ere y're, it's ya mum!" As the punchline lands, the two men burst into hysterical laughter.

If you did not get the joke, do not fret, you are less beset by British school boy humour. But in brief, the main man has pretended to receive a phone call from a mystery female engaged in a deeply sexual conversation, who he suddenly reveals to be his friend's mother. Whilst the elaborate set piece sexualises

and demoralises women — which should *not* be funny — is it difficult to watch the video without chortling at the punchline because the men's hooting laughter is utterly infectious. It's like when someone yawns and you involuntarily yawn, unknowingly hungry for oxygen.

The adoption of an anthropological approach to online speech that is sensitive to emic categories should get us closer to understanding the political grievances and social issues that motivate speakers into ritual forms of extremism. Cross-culturally, Katiambo discussed *Utani* in Kenya, a Swahili discursive form, that "allows insults in a playful way" [6]. Not dissimilar to British banter, Swahili *Utani* uses jokes and humour to make the public unsayable. However, what is different between *Utani* and banter is that, in a highly politicised media environment with a long history of silencing ethnic communities, *Utani's* playful insults are less about extreme views, and more about allowing subaltern voices the space to interact with and resist oppression. On Kenyan social media, *Utani* has been labelled as hate speech by political opponents and banned by authoritative governments, even though its visibility functions to facilitate conflict de-escalation through humour (Katiambo, 2021). Quite differently, on U.K. social media, digital banter appears to veil extremism in a way that disarms criticism and emboldens speakers — underwritten by the infectious laughter of dominant (male) voices.

I do not suggest that digital banter should be unilaterally permitted on social media because of its specificity as a British cultural phenomenon. However, when considered as a repertoire of extreme speech, digital banter is demonstrative of the importance of attention to cultural specificity, even in a language as seemingly banal and widespread as English, among Internet cultures. The discourse of digital banter may be despicable, but the anthropological extreme speech framework tries to not vilify or marginalise speakers, before considering the way political grievances that underpin their extremism serve to build community and identity. The idea of infectiousness has been used effectively in discussions on how content on social media spreads. We know that medical related disinformation, the kinds of dangerous conspiracy narratives that developed around COVID-19, creates an infodemic. Equally, contagious theory has been developed around online virality to find an appropriate metaphor to describe the way networks and connectivity create rapid spread. The way speech acts have been theorised as infectious can be traced back to Tarde's nineteenth-century theory of how "discourse is intimately interwoven with a pre-discursive flow of contagious affect, feelings, and emotions" [7]. Internet connectivity may increase the velocity and intensity of information spread, but it is not the cause of spread in the first instance. As an affective process that evokes and demands emotion, the humour in digital banter serves to promote status and galvanise group identities, thereby creating the parameters for exclusion and inclusion.

The way banter serves to forge identity, and therefore creates an "us versus them" distinction, is clearly visible in the second video recommended by YouTube following my '*What is banter?*' prompt. The video, titled, "Trying banter for the first time | An immigrant's guide to Britain", is presented as a serious segment from UK TV's Channel 4 News, but it is *actually* a satirical parody made for Channel 4 Entertainment (see Figure 2). The video starts in a busy London market street — another quintessential working-class environment — with an Indian man playing the role of a stooge saying he has "come here to learn about banters ... because it is an essential part of British life". By saying "banters" — a grammatically incorrect noun — the Indian man instantly exposes himself as an outsider and someone who is not very likely to grasp the intricacies of British banter. He's then shown asking two burly white market street sellers: "*What is banter?*" In full working class patois, one replies: "It's the way that *we* speak. It's a *lingo*. It's a different *kind* of speech". The other man continues: "It's an instant thing, it's not something you practice, it just happens".



Figure 2: Comedic sketch of a documentary exploring ‘what is banter’ for immigrants in the U.K.

When the two white men say that banter is not something you can learn they imply it is innate and indigenous, and therefore not something for outsiders to grasp. Presented as a serious news segment, I am certain that to any ordinary *outsider* the video is difficult to interpret as comedic fiction. Even to myself — a mixed-race English *insider* from a working class background — it took me several viewings and readings of the user comments to gather that the singularly produced sketch was not an earnest news exposé exploring what banter means for immigrants and people of colour in the U.K., but a parody of one — and therefore not another blatant example of banter being celebrated without its negative consequences being questioned. However, as a parody it is doing exactly that: demonstrating the problematic nature of “banters” (*sic*) as it creates visible lines of exclusion towards migrants and other outsiders.

These two YouTube videos appear to hold enough denotative meaning to make some broad stroke inferences. For example, the content of the digital banter throughout the videos presented are specifically working-class cultures that skew right politically and celebrate white supremacy, nationalism, and misogyny. However, whilst the white-van men and the market sellers are quintessentially working class, I believe it would be a misstep to situate digital banter as a working class phenomenon. In the lively environment of the market traders, the general understanding that banter is “the way we speak” produces an *us versus them* dictum, but I suspect analogous power structures are in play across class, ethnicity, and political lines. At the upper echelons of British society, Ex-Prime Minister and Oxford-educated dimwit Boris Johnson is renowned for his buffoon haircut and court jester-like persona. Fellow Conservative MP and Oxford alumni Jacob Rees-Mogg is similar — deemed amusing because he is so posh and removed from every life. In addition, the rise of black and brown female politicians, and the abuse they receive, is not only a conceit of the British Conservative Party. In the Labour Party, a list of black and brown female politicians have been publicly shamed in the last two years. Diane Abbott, the first black woman elected to Parliament, is the regular target of abuse; Apsana Begum, the U.K.’s first MP to wear a hijab, had the whip

removed; Zarah Sultana and Faiza Shaheen were forced out of the party altogether. It should go without saying that misogyny and racism are not working-class phenomena. And banter, whether digitalised or not, is the wordplay of the British man, which operates across class to denigrate others deemed inferior by culture, gender, and race.

Methodology

This paper explores the novel concept of digital banter on fringe social media platform Bitchute as a repertoire of extreme speech that veils various forms of extremism. By engaging in an interpretive content analysis of the videos that are posted by so-called banter merchants, and comments by viewers, I demonstrate the ways in which audiences simultaneously engage in digital banter, a phenomenon that I situate within a framework of extreme speech that recognises context and culturally coded circumstances. As a trained anthropologist, my methodological practice is deep immersion amongst host communities in order to engage in long-term changes in the community norms and observe the "silence of the social" — *i.e.*, what people say they do is often very different to what they actually do (Hirschauer, 2006). However, gaining access to banter merchants specifically was challenging, as they did not reply to invitations to participate in the research. Nevertheless, the work engages in a form of digital ethnography, where I spent eight months across 10 fringe platforms analysing common forms of content creation and engagement (*i.e.*, video content uploads, user comments beneath videos, user/influencer interactions, types of conversations and subjects being discussed) and theorizing how these engagement dynamics shape the community that was established. Specific videos on female politicians were selected on the back of recent scandals with a specific interest in looking at how humour operates to veil extreme speech. Of course, the videos analysed cannot represent the entirety of the banter archive, but rather they have been selected to highlight themes and trends that exist within this social phenomenon. This work also puts recent scholarship on extreme speech in conversation with work on (anti)fan studies and celebrity studies, in order to expand discursive categories of how social media "influence" and British "humour" are practised and theorised within a digital, neoliberal context.

Celebrity anti-fandom

The first argument that I want to make is that we should understand that the digital banter expressed by Count Dankula is an example of anti-fandom, which was described by Gray as "active or vocal dislike or hate of a given text, personality, or genre" [8]. In his earliest work on fan cultures, Gray (2003) made distinctions between fans, non-fans, and anti-fans, providing unheralded definitions of the latter two since media scholars had seldom considered those who engaged in media but did not enjoy it, or those who actively mobilised against it. Much later, delving deeper into the participatory modes of dislike that occurred among individuals in a fully mediatised Internet age, Gray (2019) identified four typologies of anti-fandom. The first is *competitive* anti-fandom for "when dislike (whether serious or playful) is directed at a perceived rival of one's beloved fan object" [9]. Then there is *bad object anti-fandom* — a broad feeling of dislike towards something being "bad" based on "moral, aesthetic, affective or political" subjectivities [10]. Third is *anti-fans anti-fandom* which is less concerned with the object of fandom, *per se*, but specifically targeted at fans of a said object. Finally, *disappointed anti-fandom* relates to a reversal in fandom when a former fan of something generates negative feelings about its reputation or trajectory. While clearly distinct from traditional fan cultures, there is significant overlap between fandom and anti-fandom with behaviours, attitudes, and traits not only resembling, but actively imitating each other. Gray (2021) argued that disliking something is "a deeply relational act", arguing that our dislike for something is rarely aimed at a single object, but instead "regularly overflows" to tell us "a lot about the disliker's

relations with other people, with other texts, with ethics of media practice, with representational systems, and with other yearnings and needs for the media" [11]. In short, anti-fandom can be seen as a gateway into a wider political economy and cultural affect.

By situating Count Dankula's video about U.K. politician Suella Braverman's sacking as a form of anti-fandom, we open the door to how digital banter relates to the wider media ecosystem and specifically to the discursive toxicity that embodies contemporary celebrity culture. Early theories of celebrity culture formerly emphasized the unfathomable X factor of media icons, most notably Hollywood movie stars. However, more recently, celebrities have been more broadly defined as "those who are well-known beyond those with whom they have direct contact" [12]. Present-day celebrity therefore incorporates a much broader spectrum of individuals, including academics, experts, journalists, influencers, and politicians, as a result of visibility afforded by social media. Scholars from across disciplines have pondered what is the meaning and contribution of celebrities to modern society. Tyler and Bennett (2010) argued that celebrity sustains and reproduces class relations. Via an analysis of so-called "Celebrity Chavs" they noted that "celebrity is an increasingly significant means by which reactionary class attitudes, allegiances and judgements are communicated" [13]. "Chav" is a British-ism denoting working class people with poor taste and prospects. Celebrity chavs emerged as a novel cohort through reality television's subjugation of *real* people "with a pleasurable blend of contempt, envy, scepticism and prurience" [14]. Celebrity produces and sustains class relations because celebrities — whether working class 'never-do-wells' or *literal* royalty — become the nodal point of discussion around the levels and parameters of acceptability, decency, and despicability. Philosophers have explored the way that celebrities function as the object of everyday gossip, discursively defining themselves as moral exemplars and role models (Archer and Sie, 2023). Anthropologists have long sought gossip as an important way in which humans share information about one another and how the norms and values characteristic of our communities are contested. However, strictly gossiping about those in our close proximity has pitfalls and leads to harm to individuals and communities locally. Thus, by focusing our gossip on the rich and famous we explore the moral contours of life — often to the extreme, via the extravagance and pomposity of celebrities' lives — whilst safeguarding those around us. Celebrity lives therefore provide benchmarks, checks and balances if you will, between the realms of our actual lives and what is possible. The suggestion is: next time you want to judge someone for watching *I'm a Celebrity, Get Me Out of Here*, or doomscrolling through a celebrity's TikTok feed, perhaps they are weighing up the moral value of these different styles of living in order to determine the guardrails of their own lives and ambitions.

Celebrities, including highly visible politicians, increasingly play a role as proxies for campaigns against specific groups of people. By reproducing class relations and becoming nodal points of morality and gossip, a highly divisive individual such as Braverman becomes the object of digital banter expressing racist and misogynistic views that test the limits of normative modes of acceptability. In the specific video documenting Braverman's downfall, Count Dankula's anti-fandom appears to primarily adopt one of Gray's four-set categorizations. By explicitly discrediting Braverman based on her femaleness, non-British ancestry, and the colour of her skin, he is, in other words, classifying the politician as a bad object predicated on *moral, aesthetic, affective, and political* issues of gender and race. Following Gray, a growing number of scholars are grappling with the darker sides of fan cultures. Salter and Blodgett (2017) identified misogyny as a core trope that courses through fan cultures, all the while building the so-called manosphere comprised of various groups including, incels, pick-up artists (PUAs) and men's rights activists (MRA), amongst others (Ging and Siapera, 2019; Haslop, *et al.*, 2024). The notorious Gamergate scandal saw swarms of vitriolic gamers mobilise against a female journalist that quickly snowballed into a fully fledged purge of women, feminists, non-white people, and antiracists from the gaming world (Massanari, 2017). While racist anti-black and antisemitic attitudes appear to go hand-in-glove with online misogyny, Meier and Sharp (2024) reminded us to be careful not to automatically conflate misogyny and racism, because active anti-women communities are prevalent across nationalities and ethnicities. Misogyny is not *only* a white-man syndrome. That being said, in the context of English banter as a repertoire of extreme speech on fringe platforms, white men appear to be the overwhelming voice of celebrity anti-fandom. It is in such an environment that "celebrities serve as proxies for hated groups of people" [15]. While an anti-fan may claim to not like a brown, female politician based on ideological incompatibility, the dislike itself is a

manifestation of entrenched racism and/or misogyny, not political incongruence, *per se*.

Nevertheless, I believe we should not confect anti-fandom as a form of hate speech, because the accusation of 'hate speech' is a normative descriptor at times weaponized by the powerful to muzzle opposition and nullify dissent. Following Jane (2014), who advocated for a more inclusive approach to content moderation on social media that seeks to understand context and culture before labelling something as hateful and, therefore, ready for removal, Meier and Sharp described anti-fans as "produsers" [16]. Thus, by seeing anti-fans as produsers in highly reciprocal networked communities, we can shift "the focus of anti-fandom from individual textual consumers to textually productive communities, within which performances of dislike serve to clarify and negotiate a stable group identity" [17]. In all its toxic irony and veiled extremity, Count Dankula's video on Suella Braverman is demonstrative of how Bitchute affords creators the freedom to produce anti-fandom celebrity content, and interact with their own fans/anti fans.

The concept of 'parasocial relationships' describes the familiar, intimate relationships that we as audiences and consumers cultivate with media personalities. In its original conceptualisation, Horton and Wohl (1956) discussed the one-sided relationships that celebrities of television, film, and radio fostered with their fans. "Intimacy at a distance" described audiences who felt they had a deep connection with their icons despite the relationship being wholly one-sided and unreciprocated [18]. Building on this concept, Abidin (2015; 2013) noted that intimacy is central to the way that social media influencers generate passionate and loyal engagement from fans. In her view, the dialogic affordances of social media have shifted the logics of parasocial relationships. Influencers engage in reciprocal intimacies where social media personalities create the illusion that the relationship is reciprocated by responding directly to comments and giving shout outs to followers. Interestingly, Mardon, *et al.* (2023) argued that this emergent reciprocal intimacy is more prone to sudden and treacherous downfalls to anti-fandom because influencers that become very popular through the maintenance of reciprocal intimacies cannot maintain a level of intimacy with all of their fans when their followings grow into the thousands or more. They argued that, unlike traditional celebrities, influencers' initial online presence is built from grassroots interactions, unmediated by management teams that carefully cultivate the public persona of celebrities. Influencers therefore develop high levels of intimacy amongst followers, but the high bar of intimacy set by influencers is more precarious because, when the "intimacy pact" (Berryman and Kavka, 2017) is inevitably broken, they are more likely to attract anti-fan backlash. In the next section I relate celebrity anti-fandom banter to influencers via the notion of a 'banter merchant'.

Anti-fan banter merchants

Count Dankula is one of many social media influencers dealing in political anti-fandom on Bitchute. As produsers, content creators engage in elaborate video blogging practices, committing significant time and energy into researching, scripting, recording, editing, and distributing their content. These kinds of content creators have been variously labelled as ideological entrepreneurs (Finlayson, 2023), political influencers (Riedl, *et al.*, 2023), and even digital activists (Kaun and Uldam, 2018). The second argument that I make is to purposely call these kinds of English-language political commentators "banter merchants". Content creators such as Count Dankula are banter merchants because the modes of engagement that they deal in to generate dislike are based on humour and (not) "taking offence" in the English-language tradition of banter. While I resist a lengthy definitional debate, I have often found the term "influencers" — and its various derivatives, "lifestyle" influencers, "political" influencers, and other variants — to be slightly disingenuous because of its proclivity to ignore or obfuscate the underlying pecuniary orientations of acquiring influence on social media. Calling these creators banter merchants shows an awareness and anticipation of the financial imperatives motivating social media content creators to accrue political influence through comedic anti-fandom. Whilst not previously scholarly defined, "banter merchant" is common parlance in the U.K. A Google search reveals various examples of the term's use, including a 2024 Sky News report [19] about a Glaswegian hotel hiring a "banter merchant" to "roast" guests at breakfast, and a Scottish homeware brand

selling crockery and other home-based paraphernalia with “a Scottish twist” — or in other words, crass or borderline-offensive slogans. Google’s AI service Gemini suggests banter merchant is “a slang term for someone who is skilled at or enjoys engaging in playful, humorous, and often provocative banter”.

For the purpose of depth rather than breadth, let us explore more content relating specifically to Suella Braverman’s sacking on Bitchute via other banter merchants dealing in similar repertoires of political anti-fandom. Figure 3 displays the notable spike in videos uploaded with “Braverman” in the title around the middle of November 2023. Braverman was officially sacked on 13 November 2023, the date the spike peaks at 12 video uploads, and Count Dankula published his mocking critique on 15 November. The other videos clearly reinforce the prevalence of digital banter on U.K. fringe social media. One video, published by the group collective known as The Lotus Eaters, covered the Braverman story in their daily 1pm live show. Rather than focus on the sacking of Braverman, they led with the headline “Suella Braverman Absolutely Torches Rishi Sunak”, emphasising the ferocity of her (involuntary) resignation letter that relieved her from official government duties without remorse. The Lotus Eaters’ daily show attempts to emulate professional television panel shows, filmed in a well-lit studio with large microphones in the foreground and graphics on a green screen (Figure 4). The three speakers — two smartly dressed in suits, the other choosing a more “chilled” tech-bro hoodie style — are all millennial white males. Another of their shows, *Lads Hours* (Figure 5), is a weekly session that brings together a panel of white, male speakers, that plugs into an aesthetic of the U.S.-Euro manosphere: a class English pub, pints of beer, pool table, and blonde barmaids in Bavarian garb (the dirndl dress is a sexualised costume consisting of a close-fitting bodice, revealing blouse, short skirt, and stockings). Another extremely popular Bitchute banter merchant contributing to the Suella conversation in mid-November 2023 goes by the username Styxhexenhammer666 (Figure 6). With well over 100,000 subscribers, this American influencer is visually distinct from his British commentaries. His Jesus aesthetic and wellness vibe seem incongruent with the Brits of The Lotus Eaters who all favour short, sharp haircuts, and manly demeanours. One more Bitchute channel of interest, WEGOTAPROBLEM, reneges on the influencer-style presentation all together, instead streaming library images gleaned from news broadcasts and social media, and narrativized with a droll English male voiceover. While the bodily presentations may differ significantly between the lad cultures of Count Dankula and The Lotus Eaters, the Americana of Styxhexenhammer666, and the anonymity of WEGOTAPROBLEM, they are unified by their inherent whiteness and maleness. Exceptionally, I did find one diverse content creator talking about British politics on the fringe social media. Mahyar Tousi is an Iranian migrant based in the U.K. who has built a large and profitable following discussing current affairs and interviewing public figures. His content is notably distinct from banter merchants, however, because there is a lack of humorous histrionics: his tone is serious and earnest. Seemingly, as a brown outsider, Mahyar Tousi is not, and cannot be, a banter merchant.

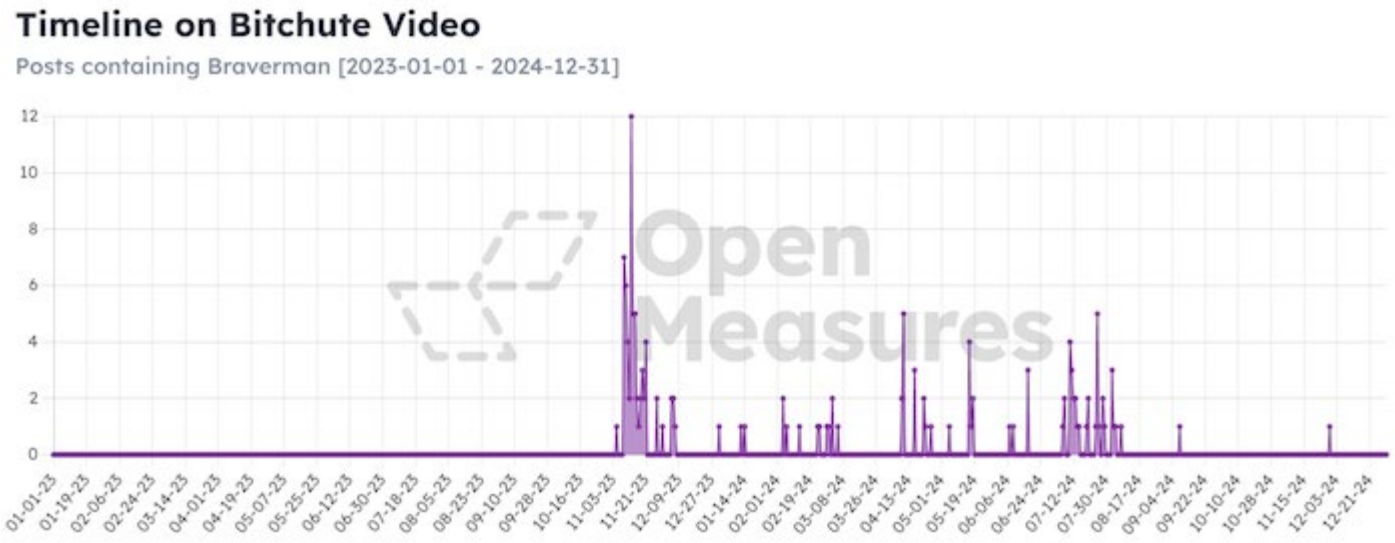


Figure 3: Spike in Braverman videos around her dismissal in mid-November 2023. Following that, Braverman becomes a more regularly featured headline and topic of content.



Figure 4: The Lotus Eaters, a popular video blogging and podcast U.K. collective, espouse right wing and conspiratorial content.



Figure 5: *Lads Hours* is defined by its pub-like aesthetic.



Figure 6: Styxhexenhammer666 is a hugely influential American banter merchant. His cult-leader and wellness aesthetic is distinct from his British contemporaries.

One of the most prominent, reoccurring tropes on scholarship about content creators on social media is the relationship with labour and profit. The relationship is so entrenched that Cirucci (2018) argued that all social networking interactions are a form of labour because the platform exploits users in order to extract data and profit. Whilst being utilised by the platform, banter merchants, like influencers, have ambitions of building their own followings and fame via controversial political anti-fandom with a goal of converting views into income. Abidin described influencers as "ordinary Internet users who accumulate a relatively large following on blogs and social media through the textual and visual narration of their personal lives and lifestyles, engage with their following in digital and physical spaces, and monetise their following by integrating 'advertorials' into their blog or social media posts" [20]. Banter merchants do not deal in the typology of sponsored content favoured by traditional lifestyle influencers. As previously mentioned, Bitchute relies solely on subscriptions, donations, and advertisers for income, and, so it seems, banter merchants also predominately rely on fan donations, with their public profiles backlinking to monetisation platforms. It is striking and perhaps under-theorized that Bitchute's platform norms and affordances of subscriptions over sponsored content appear to be mirrored by their most successful content creators. We may infer that Instagram's most prolific influencers are well adjusted to integrating 'advertorials' into their content because Instagram skews heavily to highly curated content and targeted ads geared at shopping and

lifestyle.

Following further investigation into Count Dankula and other content creators thriving with comedic/offensive content on British current affairs, I was surprised to learn that the Count is a hugely influential star on YouTube with over one million followers. In addition, his YouTube account links to various platforms and portals, some more popular than others. He also has 75,000 followers on X and 27k followers on Facebook. Due to the fact that Count Dankula is a hugely successful social media personality with various revenue streams, especially on a major platform where his extraordinary following would convert to lucrative advertising revenue, it would appear that his Bitchute account — where he posted the Suella Braverman appraisal — is merely an adjunct to his wider network and influence across the U.K.'s manosphere. While some video content is repeated across all platforms, on the "About" page of his Bitchute profile Count Dankula describes the account as "for stuff that isn't good enough for the main channel" (Figure 7). While I cannot attest for the quality of videos on the YouTube accounts versus Bitchute videos, I suspect Bitchute provides an alternative space to publish content possibly more incendiary, whilst addressing a smaller, and perhaps more radical audience.

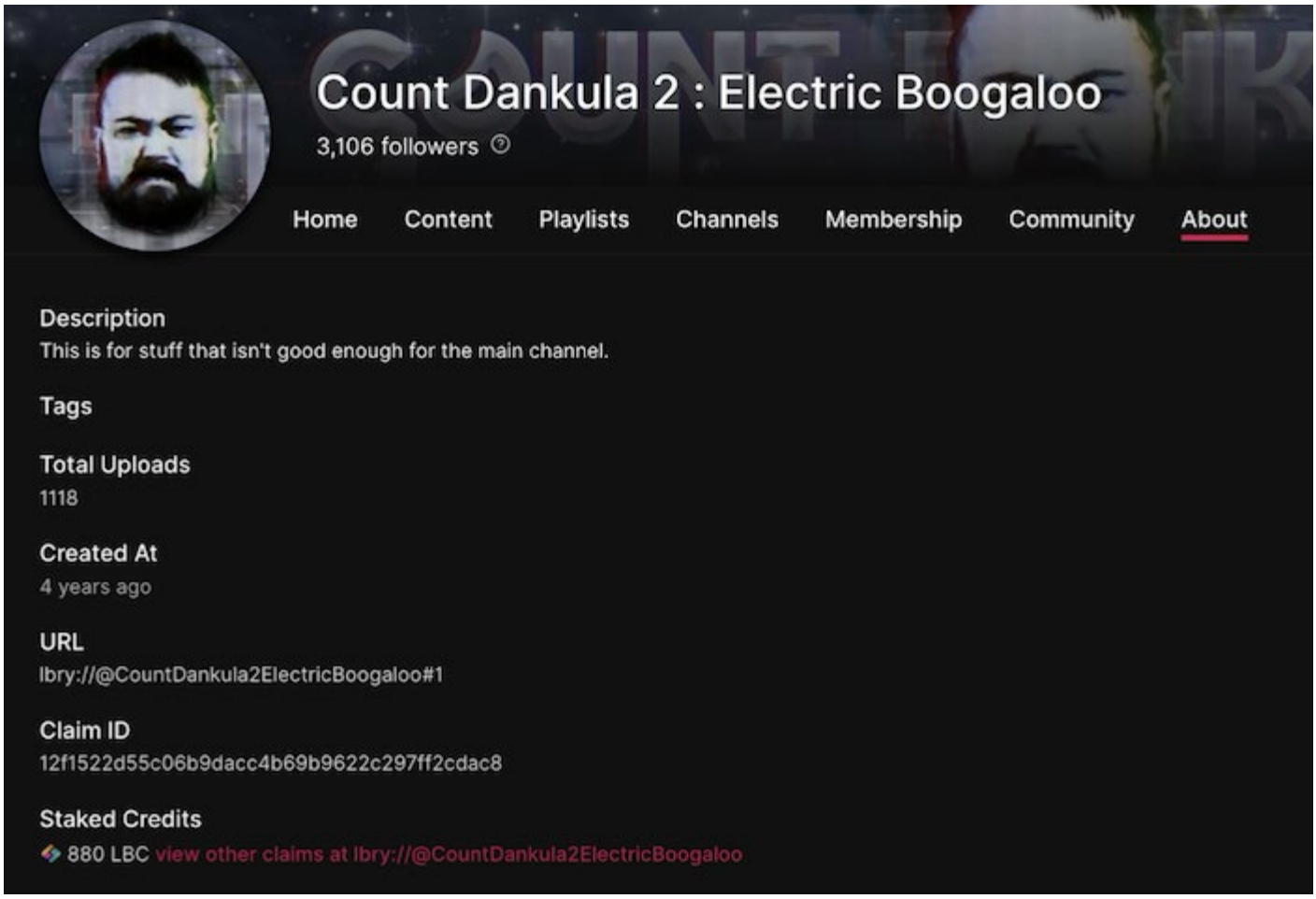


Figure 7: Count Dankula secondary Bitchute account described as "for stuff that isn't good enough for the main channel."

The consistent backlinking of social media platforms to accessible monetisation portals create a centralised network of labour and profit. The most influential or popular banter merchants have the most subscriptions

portals, and these monetisation platforms differ in product offerings and affordances. For example, subscription portals such as Patreon and Subscribestar offer access to paywalled content, while PayPal allows for one-off donations. Additionally, income of a banter merchant is further supplemented via merch stores such as Teespring, offering a range of products with brands and slogans. Following classic corporate marketing strategies, t-shirts, mugs, tote bags, and car and laptop stickers are not only products aimed at fans, but marketing tools as well. By investing in Count Dankula products and sporting them in public, the products transform fans into advertisers enhancing the visibility and popularity of specific banter merchants.

Concluding discussion: Connecting anti-fandom banter and banter merchants

It is perhaps obvious, but nevertheless important to note, that humour sells. The banter merchants under analysis are everyday social media users with lofty ambitions of becoming social media celebrities. The narratives and vernacular forms that they adopt to achieve their goals are layered with highly-localised humour, wherein "deriving fun from the sheer freshness of colloquialism in political debates, which stands in contrast to the serious tone of political deliberation and official centricity, and by mainstreaming the witty political campaign styles as an everyday form of political communication" [21] is directed, in this case, towards a class of brown female political leaders. While it is no doubt satisfying, and arguably necessary, in a functioning democracy for citizens to discuss politics in vernacular, including sharing content on social media, the intricacies at play here are important. Count Dankula's 21,000 followers on Bitchute may well seem miniscule in a social media milieu dealing in metrics that routinely rolls into the millions, but Dankula's Bitchute following is a subsidiary of his wider influence across the multi-platform manosphere.

Banter merchant such as Count Dankula, The Lotus Eaters, Styxhexenhammer666, and WEGOTAPROBLEM are visually and textually very different. Yet, despite clear differences in personal styles and content detailing Braverman's sacking, the comments section in the videos is homogeneously scathing and conspiratorial. Not only do the comments reveal much about the climate of British politics, they also demonstrate how digital banter operates to veil extremism and build community by what I call 'networked parasocial relationships'. The combination of male creators broadcasting up-to-the-date news commentary on a highly divisive female leader — largely mocking a political downfall — encourages a community of viewers to add to a toxic soup of discussion. Naturally, the banter merchants reproduce the expected parasocial relationship between themselves and their own followers, but they also mediate an additional parasocial relationship between the "bad object" of their anti-fandom — in this case British politician Suella Braverman — and their wider public on fringe social media.

The role adopted by banter merchants appears to be reminiscent of "reputational entrepreneurs" (Fine, 2019, 2001, 1996). According to Fine, "reputational entrepreneurs attempt to control the memory of historical figures through motivation, narrative facility, and institutional placement" [22]. In his analysis combining Durkheimian functionalism and symbolic anthropology, which sees symbols as the sites of power contestation and cultural production, Fine's concept treats how status is earned and maintained in society. While predating the social media era, Fine appears to pre-empt an emergent digital milieu saturated with content creators taking positions as gatekeepers and arbiters of taste and status. Fine's analysis is especially relevant here because of his emphasis on the "misdeeds or violations of norms as embedded in the recall of scandal" [23] as central to reputations. As Gray focused his attention on anti-fans rather than fans, and dislike over like, Fine argued that it is character pitfalls and flaws that memorialise individuals rather than their achievements and successes. Suella Braverman is, therefore, an obvious object of dislike for banter merchants because her populist and hateful views and policies on immigration, plus her non-white ethnicity and womanhood, co-create a *networked parasocial relationship* that intensifies follower anti-fandom and therefore elevates their own popularity. As Figure 3 illustrates, before her sacking, Braverman was largely ignored on Bitchute, despite being the U.K.'s foreign secretary for several years.

Yet, after her dismissal, she became a regular video topic and headline. The willingness to focus so much attention on Braverman after her sacking suggests that banter merchants become cognizant of "bad objects" with the potential to generate intense *networked* parasocial relationships, ultimately serving their underlying financial imperatives.

When banter merchants deploy digital banter to describe the foibles of black and brown female politicians, they are encouraging others below the line to say the unsayable by deploying a mix of humour, slang, and hyper-vernacularised speech forms. The nurturing of networked parasocial relationships by banter merchants on Bitchute therefore establishes a normative code of conduct for prospective viewers and followers about how to discuss politics on Bitchute. Beneath Count Dankula's video there is conspicuous antisemitism. Referring to Braverman's Jewish husband, the most popular comment noted: "Married to a kike. Foreign Infiltrator. Fuck off back to your own country. I want my country back". The antisemitism is more discreet on WEGOTAPROBLEM's videoblog. Someone posted "(((Braverman))) ... not an Indian name now, is it", deploying coded netspeak typology of three brackets around a name to indicate their Jewishness and therefore flag them as suspicious. Other commentators mock specific characters in the revolving door of British politics. Ex-Prime Minister David Cameron was named as Braverman's replacement as Foreign Secretary, and so Cameron evolved into an object of digital banter. "Dave the pig fucker returns to the circus," remarked one commentator, referring to a widespread rumour that Cameron had inserted his penis into a pig's head as a dare for an initiation ceremony into a student society at the University of Oxford. The narratives descend into pitiful play-fighting and name-calling between Bitchute users. There is a lot of talk of genitalia, including the merits and perils of circumcision, tabling persistent antisemitic tropes via playground vernacular.

These comments are despicable, but to Bitchute commentators, these interactions are playful chat in the British tradition of banter. The explicit nods to antisemitism and racism are in-jokes that build a moral community outlining the rules of acceptability and defining the group identity as broadly anti-establishment. Alt-tech platforms, such as Bitchute, intensify the extremity of speech in the public sphere. Those profiting from political anti-fandom are banter merchants whose regular video "hot takes" curate banter forums for normies to do battle below the line. But let me not overemphasis Count Dankula's despicability as a Bitchute problem, for he thrives on major platforms. Moreover, despicable banter expounded by male icons flourishes throughout the British media and political ecosystem.

About the author

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Notes

1. Jobert and Sorlin, 2018, p. 10.

2. Pohjonen and Udupa, 2017, p. 1,173.

3. Gray, 2019, p. 28.

4. Jobert and Sorlin, 2018, p. 10.

5. https://www.gov.uk/government/publications/online-safety-act-explainer/online-safety-act-explainer.

6. Katiambo, 2021, p. 51.

7. Sampson, 2012, p. 3.

8. Gray, 2005, p. 841.

9. Gray, 2019, p. 26.

10. Gray, 2019, pp. 28–29.

11. Gray, 2021, p. 4.

12. Archer and Sie, 2023, p. 342.

13. Tyler and Bennett, 2010, p. 375.

14. *Ibid.*

15. Gray, 2021, p. 7.

16. Meier and Sharp, 2024, p. 352.

17. *Ibid.*

18. Horton and Wohl, 1956, p. 215.

19. https://news.sky.com/story/hotel-looking-to-hire-banter-merchant-to-entertain-guests-during-edinburgh-festival-fringe-13175451.

20. Abidin, 2015, p. 1.

21. Udupa, 2019, p. 3,144.

22. Fine, 1996, p. 1,159.

23. Fine, 2019, p. 247.

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